excluding any section of Indian society (for instance, minorities who reject the Hindu idea of *dharma* as irrelevant to their lives) from their rightful place in the Indian sun. If we can bring *dharma* into our national life, it must be to uphold, rather than at the expense of, the pluralist ideal of Indian-ness.

Hinduism has always acknowledged the existence of opposites (and reconciled them): pain and pleasure, success and failure, creation and destruction, life and death are all manifestations of the duality inherent in human existence. These pairings are not contradictory but complementary; they are aspects of the same overarching reality. So also with the secular and the sacred: a Hindu's life must involve both. To acknowledge this would both absorb and deflect the unsavoury aspects of the resurgence of Hindutva.

## THE RSS AND SAVARKAR

India's current ruling party, the Bharatiya Janata Party, officially adopted Hindutva as its defining credo in 1989. It is the doctrine assiduously promoted by the Hindu nationalist volunteer organisation the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), founded in 1925, and its affiliated family of organisations in the 'Sangh Parivar', notably the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP, World Hindu Council), set up in 1964 with an avowed intention of protecting and promoting the Hindu religion. The word Hindutva is widely used by all of them, but what does the term actually mean?

The man largely credited with the invention of the concept of Hindutva—literally 'Hinduness'—is Vinayak Damodar Savarkar (1883–1966), whose *Essentials Of Hindutva* (Bombay: Veer Savarkar Prakashan, 1st edn 1923) laid out the concept. Republished in 1928 as *Hindutva: Who Is a Hindu?*, it is in many ways the foundational text of the Hindu nationalist creed.

Savarkar chose the term 'Hindutva' to describe the 'quality of being a Hindu' in ethnic, cultural and political terms. He argued that a Hindu is one who considers India to be his motherland (*matrbhumi*), the land of his ancestors (*pitrbhumi*), and his holy land (*punya bhumi*). India is the land of the Hindus since their ethnicity is Indian and since the Hindu faith originated in India. (Other faiths that were born in India, like